

Figure I.11 *Mosque of Kaman, Rajasthan, India, founded* c. *1195. Exterior: eastern façade with main entrance. © Photograph Alka Patel 2011.*

technologies and modes of communication constantly becoming available. On a more humble (and more optimistic) level, however, the present volumes' treatment of the Shansabanis at least mitigates their historiographical displacement. At the same time, I believe the subject presents important opportunities to craft much-needed methodological alternatives for approaching the historical pasts of South and Central Asia.

In their magisterial work titled *Empires in World History*, J. Burbank and F. Cooper proposed a capacious conceptualization of empires, *viz.* "large political units, expansionist or with a memory of power extended over space … that maintain distinction and hierarchy as they incorporate new people." Such a working definition not only leaves room for a great variety of politico-economic hierarchical structures – that is, empires – through time, it also respects their staggering complexity. Burbank and Cooper's definition easily encompasses such dissimilar entities as the Roman and Mongol empires, bookending two soft ends of a spectrum of imperialisms: Rome, with its "notion of a single, superior imperial civilization open in principle to those who could learn its ways"; *versus* the Mongols, who "learned their statecraft from both Eurasian and Chinese sources … sheltered Buddhism, Confucianism, Christianity, Daoism, and Islam; [and] where diversity was treated as both normal and useful."[14]

But a singular term for such a vast array of human organizations certainly belies the virtually infinite possibilities for their origins; their subsequent expansions and contractions; and their internal political, economic, social, and other operations. Empires were never instantaneous,